Little Nine Heaven Internal Kung-Fu

The Complete Guide to the Systems, Masters & Taoist Martial Tradition



LITTLE NINE HEAVEN INTERNAL KUNG-FU

The Complete Guide to the Systems, Masters & Taoist Martial Tradition

Compiled from the L9H Newsletters — 2009 to Present

Sifu James W. McNeil
Gate Keeper, Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao System

TABLE OF CONTENTS

Introduction: One Man's Destiny

The journey that shaped a lineage

Chapter 1: The Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao System

Origins, philosophy, and the three pillars

Chapter 2: The Masters Who Shaped the Art

Seven teachers — seven transformations

- Master Haumea F. Lefiti (Tiny) — *The first door*
- Master Ralph Shun — *Shaolin Five Animals & Iron Hand*
- Master Hsu Hong-Chi — *Hsing-I, Shih Shui & Taoist tradition*
- Master Chin Cheng-Yen — *Tzu Men Chuan & pressure-point mastery*
- Master Pan Wing-Chou — *Chen Tai-Chi — the original form*
- Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung — *The Gate Keeper and the complete system*
- Master Hsu Ting-Ming — *Psychic Healing — the seventh master*

Chapter 3: The Internal Kung-Fu Systems

A practitioner's overview

- Hsing-I Chuan — Mind-Body Boxing — *The five elements in combat*
- Ba-Kua Zhang — Eight Trigram Palm — *Dragon style circle walking*
- Chen Tai-Chi — The Original Form — *700 years of living medicine*
- Splashing Hands (Zahn Zhou Chuan) — *Explosive Shaolin street fighting*
- Tzu Men Chuan — Poison Finger Style — *Darting strikes & vital-point targeting*

Chapter 4: Core Techniques & Training Methods

What the masters teach

- Iron Hand Training — *Conditioning without calluses*
- Shih Shui Kung — Bone Marrow Washing — *The fountain of youth*
- The 18 Ground Maneuvers — *L9H's grappling art*

- Chi Kung & Meditation — *Internal cultivation and the Taoist path*
- The Eight Fundamentals of Hsing-I — *Structural alignment for power and health*

Chapter 5: Philosophy, Lineage & Legacy

Preserving the old ways

Chapter 6: Psychic Healing

The art of chi-based healing

Closing Words from Sifu McNeil

Publications & Accomplishments

Books, DVDs, articles, and a world-wide reach

INTRODUCTION

One Man's Destiny

The story of Little Nine Heaven Internal Kung-Fu in the West cannot be separated from the story of one man — Sifu James W. McNeil. Born in Webster Groves, Missouri, McNeil's path to becoming the first and only American Gate Keeper of an ancient Taoist martial system began not with triumph, but with tragedy. In 1965, his young son was murdered. The grief was devastating, and it was his brother Frank who, in 1968, led him through the doors of a kung-fu school in California, where he met Master Haumea F. Lefiti — known simply as 'Tiny.' That single step changed everything.

Over the next five decades, McNeil trained under seven masters across the United States and Taiwan, each one opening a new chamber of knowledge. He drove trucks during the day and trained for hours every evening. He sold his prized gun collection to fund his first flight to Taiwan. He endured three-hour waits on a master's porch without complaint, understanding that patience is itself part of the teaching. He was the only American to undergo the official discipleship ceremony at the Huang Ti Temple in Taipei.

In January 1999, Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung sent McNeil a formal letter designating him the Gate Keeper of the Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao System — a system once considered lost by the Chinese government, secretly preserved in Taiwan under decades of quiet dedication. Today the system is practiced in more than 25 countries.

This guide draws on over a decade of newsletters published by Sifu McNeil, gathering the history, the systems, the teachers, and the core techniques into a single resource. It is written for those who want to understand what genuine traditional internal kung-fu looks like — its depth, its demands, and its extraordinary gifts to health, longevity, and martial skill.

> ***"I have spent 40 years conditioning my hands and training this art. My hands have no callus anywhere and are smooth and soft — yet they can break anything."***
>
> ***— Sifu James W. McNeil***

CHAPTER 1

The Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao System

Origins of an Ancient Art

The Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao system is widely regarded as the oldest known Taoist martial art. Recently discovered records have traced the system back more than 5,000 years, unchanged, to its Taoist origins under the Yellow Emperor Huang Ti. The system was preserved in strict secrecy, passed from master to disciple by word of mouth across generations, and came close to being lost entirely during China's revolutionary upheavals of the twentieth century.

Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung trained at the San Quin Taoist Temple on Yi Wu-Lu Mountain in China before war forced him to flee to Taiwan around 1948. In Taiwan he continued teaching Ba-Kua and Hsing-I openly, but the Little Nine Heaven system itself was shared only with a tiny number of chosen disciples — so few that kung-fu reference books in China listed the system as lost. On April 8, 2016, the Chinese government officially welcomed the system back to its homeland, recognizing Sifu McNeil as the next-generation Gate Keeper.

The Three Pillars of L9H

The complete Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao system rests on three interconnected disciplines, each building upon and strengthening the others:

- **Ju-Kung (Nine Chamber Fist)** — The fighting core of the system. Nine Chamber Fist combines active and passive body strengthening with practical self-defense. Its foundation is the Confucian concept of the merging of heaven and man, expressed through Taoist yin-yang balance. Despite its name, the system is far more than a fighting method — it is a complete philosophical and physical inheritance passed down through the centuries.

- **Chian Kuan Jen (Swordsmanship)** — The armed expression of the system's principles. The straight sword (jian) training develops sensitivity, extension of chi, and the same structural alignment demanded by the unarmed forms.
- **Shih Shui Kung (Bone Marrow Washing)** — The health and longevity cornerstone of the system. An ancient set of exercises designed to strengthen internal organs, increase vitality, and slow the aging process. Over time it dramatically enhances the immune system and the body's capacity for healing. Grandmaster Chiao brought this practice from China to Taiwan; every practitioner of authentic Shih Shui traces their lineage directly to him.

Internal vs. External — The Key Distinction

Chinese martial arts divide broadly into External and Internal families. External styles — including the many varieties of Shaolin kung-fu, karate, and most MMA training — rely on muscular size and strength to generate power. They tend to stress and break down the body over time, diminishing with age.

Internal styles work differently. In the Internal approach, power comes from the mind directing chi — the body's intrinsic life-force energy — through a chain of correctly aligned joints, from the foot rooted into the earth all the way out to the fingertips. The Internal arts nourish the body from the inside out. A practitioner grows stronger with age rather than weaker. Forms practice is itself moving chi-kung — medicinal exercise that opens meridians and maintains organ health. Internal power, when fully developed, can penetrate a properly conditioned external body in ways that muscular force cannot.

The four true Internal styles are Hsing-I Chuan, Ba-Kua Zhang, Chen Tai-Chi, and Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao. All four are represented in the curriculum taught by Sifu McNeil.

> ***"The Internal Arts encompass everything from the physical to the spiritual, from fighting to lovemaking to achieving immortality. They are a special treasure given to us by the Chinese people."***

CHAPTER 2

The Masters Who Shaped the Art

Sifu McNeil's training lineage is unusual in its breadth and depth. Where most martial artists spend a lifetime with a single teacher, McNeil studied intensively under seven masters over forty-plus years — each one chosen by fate as much as by plan. He has described each teacher's death as both loss and threshold: when one door closed, another, always richer, opened.

Master Haumea F. Lefiti — 'Tiny' (1968–1973)

Master Haumea F. Lefiti, known affectionately as 'Tiny,' was the first master to open the door of kung-fu to McNeil. A powerfully built Hawaiian practitioner of Splashing Hands kung-fu, Tiny taught with ferocity and love in equal measure. McNeil trained three hours a day under him for five years, from 1968 until Tiny's sudden death from a heart attack on February 18, 1973. Tiny saved McNeil's life in the most literal sense — pulling him back from the edge of grief and self-destruction after the murder of his son. He taught McNeil how to fight, how to endure, and how to love the art.

When Tiny died, McNeil helped his school brothers keep their schools running for six months before moving on to seek deeper knowledge — turning down offers to open his own Splashing Hands school, knowing instinctively that his journey was not yet finished.

Master Ralph Shun (1973–1977)

Master Ralph Shun was born in Honolulu, Hawaii on March 3, 1934, and died January 18, 2002. He began studying kung-fu in 1949 under Master Wong Gu Faat, learning the Unicorn style — an esoteric Hakka system targeting the centerline with attacks to the eyes, throat, and groin. Later he trained under Sil Lum Fut Ga Grandmaster Lum Dai Yong, and from 1961 became a private student of Ng Ga Kuen (Five Family System) Master Ark Yuey Wong. In 1967 Master Wong encouraged Shun to open his first school in

Huntington Park, California.

McNeil joined Master Shun's school in Crenshaw, Los Angeles after Tiny's death. Shun taught him the Shaolin Five Animal system, Wing Chun, Iron Hand, Unicorn style, Scorpion, Ng Ga Kuen, and extensive weapons training including knife-throwing. 'Ralph was an expert in weapons and other forms — he was very strict in his teachings and wanted only perfection.' McNeil trained privately with Shun on Saturdays, eventually becoming senior instructor. It was Master Shun who first introduced him to advanced Iron Hand conditioning, teaching him to soak the hands in Chinese liniment and strike progressively harder mediums — from soybeans to iron pellets. Despite leaving after five years in search of deeper internal knowledge, McNeil maintained deep respect for Shun, calling him on every holiday until his death.

Master Hsu Hong-Chi (1977–1984)

The encounter with Master Hsu Hong-Chi began with a vision. In 1975, at a kung-fu demonstration at the Scottish Rite Temple in Los Angeles, McNeil felt a sudden, overwhelming compulsion to step outside — where, passing at that exact moment, was a Chinese man he recognized without ever having met. 'That is my teacher,' he told his wife, unable to explain why. Two years later, entering a kung-fu school in Torrance, California, he saw a photograph of that same man on the wall: Master Hsu Hong-Chi. He joined immediately without asking what style was taught.

Master Hsu was born in 1934 in Taipei, Taiwan, and died suddenly in 1984. He was a master of Hsing-I Chuan, acupressure, Taoist Lovemaking, and the Shih Shui system. When he visited McNeil in California in 1977, he confided: 'From the first night I saw you, I knew I had to teach you, since I feel we have known each other in another life.' He taught McNeil special methods of hand strengthening, the advanced back-of-hand conditioning that could drive a spike into wood, and the rattlesnake medicine traditions of Taoist herbalism. In Taiwan, Hsu and McNeil would climb mountains together each morning for private training sessions, where Hsu introduced him to a White Crane master who taught additional Iron Hand techniques. When Hsu died in 1984, McNeil was the only American student to attend his funeral in Taiwan.

Master Chin Cheng-Yen

Master Chin Cheng-Yen was one of two masters to whom Grandmaster Chiao introduced McNeil before accepting him as his own student. Master Chin was the last lineage holder of Tzu Men Chuan — the 'Poison Finger' style of kung-fu — and a master of Dim Mak pressure-point striking. He and McNeil became close, spending many hours together practicing at each other's homes in California and Taiwan. Master Chin reviewed and refined McNeil's Iron Hand training, teaching him specialized exercises that significantly increased its power, and instructed him in the specific points of the human body that could kill, paralyze, or seriously injure — knowledge shared only with practitioners of advanced moral character.

Master Pan Wing-Chou (1984–1996)

Master Pan Wing-Chou was described by Grandmaster Chiao as 'the best Chen Tai-Chi master in all of China and Taiwan.' Quiet, reserved, and possessed of an almost supernatural power in push hands that McNeil called 'unheard of' and 'unbeatable,' Master Pan taught the Original Chen Tai-Chi form, Pao Twi (Cannon Fist), and fighting applications. McNeil and his senior student Al Lam were among Pan's first American students. Master Pan trained McNeil every day during his visits to Taiwan until Pan's death in 1996 — a relationship spanning twelve years and grounded in the meticulous refinement of form.

Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung (1984–2001)

Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung stands at the apex of this lineage. A titan of the Chinese internal martial arts world, Chiao trained at the San Quin Taoist Temple on Yi Wu-Lu Mountain under the reclusive master Liu Miao-Yuan, who is reputed to have still been alive in the 1960s at an age of over two hundred years. When political upheaval forced Chiao to Taiwan, he carried the Little Nine Heaven system with him, teaching only a handful of trusted disciples while the system was declared lost in China.

Grandmaster Chiao did not accept McNeil easily. After first meeting in 1984, Chiao sent McNeil to study under Masters Pan and Chin for months — watching silently from a distance before finally approaching and asking: 'Do you want to become my student?' The formal acceptance came with a test of patience: McNeil waited on Chiao's porch for three hours on three consecutive visits, never complaining, never questioning. On the fourth visit, Chiao finally began to teach. In October 1985, McNeil was accepted as a true Little Nine Heaven disciple in a formal ceremony at the Huang Ti Temple in Taipei — the first and only American ever to receive this honor. In 1999, Grandmaster Chiao sent a written letter formally naming McNeil the Gate Keeper of the entire system, a designation confirmed by oracle consultation and the casting of Yin-Yang divination blocks.

Master Hsu Ting-Ming (1988–1990)

Master Hsu Ting-Ming was the seventh master who entered McNeil's life, introducing him to the art of Psychic Healing in October 1988. From their very first meeting, Master Hsu recognized something extraordinary in McNeil, telling him: 'I can see you have a special power within you for healing and helping people. Not many people are like you. Stay and learn and one day you will see I am right.' McNeil trained with him intensively for two years, experiencing profound shifts in his internal energy — a different kind of inner strength of chi that was neither muscular nor martial, but luminous and expansive. On the final day of their first lesson, Master Hsu presented McNeil with a signed and dated copy of his book — a rare gesture of recognition between master and new student.

> ***"With each of my teachers I learned and grew. They all died with pride and accepted their fate. The cycle of life is natural and includes death."***
>
> ***— Sifu James W. McNeil***

CHAPTER 3

The Internal Kung-Fu Systems

The curriculum preserved and taught by Sifu McNeil encompasses six distinct kung-fu systems, each with its own lineage, philosophy, and fighting character. Together they form a complete martial education that develops the body from the outside in and from the inside out.

Hsing-I Chuan — Mind-Body Boxing

Hsing-I Chuan (Form-Intention Fist, or Mind-Body Boxing) is the most directly martial of the four Internal styles. Its lineage in the McNeil school runs from Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung back through Master Hsu Hong-Chi to Chi Lung Feng to the legendary general Yueh Fei and his teacher Chou Ton — one of the longest documented and unbroken lineages in Chinese martial arts.

At its core, Hsing-I is a system of straight-line attack built around the five elements — Metal, Wood, Water, Fire, and Earth — each corresponding to a fundamental striking action. Power is generated from the Tan Tien (the body's energetic center, three inches below the navel) through rooted feet and transmitted through every joint in a coordinated chain, as described in the system's Seven Stars theory: head, shoulder, elbow, hand, hip, knee, and foot are all weapons of the human body capable of striking with mortal power.

The system's combat philosophy rests on several key principles. The practitioner maintains the centerline at all times, stepping forward and orienting every movement through the nose like crosshairs on a rifle scope. The style is both offensive and defensive: it absorbs the opponent's incoming force, steps directly into close range ('close enough to kiss'), and delivers short-range power that most other styles cannot generate. The practitioner never kicks unless a full-powered strike to a vital point is fully open — raising the foot breaks the root and creates vulnerability.

An advanced Hsing-I technique is the 'shock punch' — a strike that delivers severe internal trauma rather than external bruising. It is generated by a driving motion of the hips synchronizing with the punch at the

moment of contact, causing chi erupted from the Tan Tien to transmit deep internal force through the opponent's body.

Ba-Kua Zhang — Eight Trigram Palm

Ba-Kua Zhang (Eight Trigram Palm) is the sister art of Hsing-I — where Hsing-I is linear, Ba-Kua is circular; where Hsing-I drives forward like thunder, Ba-Kua flows and turns like water. The style practiced in the L9H system is the Dragon style, traced from Grandmaster Chiao back to Yang Lu-Ling, to Ma Wei-Chi, and to Tung Hai-Chuan and his Taoist teacher before him.

The signature practice of Ba-Kua is 'circle walking' — the practitioner moves continuously around an imaginary center point using the distinctive 'mud walk' step that simultaneously develops root, hip mobility, and the ability to step behind an opponent 'like a moving shadow.' The system's primary weapons are the open palms, used in spiraling, hooking, and slicing patterns that disrupt an opponent's structure at close range.

Master Kuo Lien Ying, a famous Ba-Kua and Hsing-I master in San Francisco, was the only master recorded to have defeated Grandmaster Chiao in combat — and subsequently, the two became lifelong friends. Kuo himself was later defeated by Chiao in a rematch, and the story of their relationship illustrates the deep mutual respect that flows among masters of genuine internal skill.

Chen Tai-Chi Chuan — The Original Form

The Tai-Chi practiced in the L9H curriculum is Old Style Chen — the oldest and original form of Tai-Chi, preserved unchanged for over 700 years and the parent of all other Tai-Chi lineages. Master Pan Wing-Chou, described by Grandmaster Chiao as the finest Chen Tai-Chi practitioner in all of China and Taiwan, was McNeil's teacher in this art.

Chen Tai-Chi combines explosive fa-jin (sudden-release power) with slow, coiling silk-reeling movements. Forms practice is simultaneously a moving chi-kung exercise and a library of fighting applications. The two main forms taught are the Original Form and Pao Twi (Cannon Fist). Push-hands training develops sensitivity, rooting, and the ability to neutralize and redirect incoming force.

Unlike modern Yang, Wu, or Wu-Hao family styles — which evolved by softening Chen's explosive elements — Old Style Chen retains the full martial content. Sifu McNeil has emphasized repeatedly that altering the forms breaks the chi flow that the masters encoded into every movement: 'To alter the moves in the forms, where the magic is contained, changes the flow of chi. This is not something that must be taken on faith — it can be felt through practice.'

Splashing Hands Kung-Fu (Zahn Zhou Chuan)

Splashing Hands (Zahn Zhou Chuan) is an external soft style of Shaolin street fighting — not a true internal style, but one closely aligned with Internal principles. It was the first kung-fu system McNeil

learned, under Master Haumea Lefiti, and has remained a cornerstone of the L9H curriculum.

The style is characterized by explosive, whipping hand and foot techniques delivered at extremely close range. Unlike hard styles that rely on muscular tension, Splashing Hands uses relaxed, snapping power — like a whip — contracting only at the moment of impact and immediately releasing. The system includes Five Animal forms (Dragon, Tiger, Crane, Leopard, Snake), each building different qualities of power, speed, and chi.

The animal forms are demanding endurance exercises when practiced with full Splashing Hands speed. Stringing the forms together continuously until exhaustion builds a level of anaerobic fitness that is difficult to match by any other means. The style is particularly valuable for developing hand and foot speed, forward-closing footwork, and the ability to generate short-range explosive power.

Tzu Men Chuan — Poison Finger Style

Tzu Men Chuan (also rendered as Tzu Men Chang) is a rare Shaolin soft style that utilizes quick darting movements, primarily the fingertips, and jumping lunges to strike vulnerable anatomical points. It is inseparably linked with the advanced Iron Hand training and the Dim Mak (vital point striking) system taught by Master Chin Cheng-Yen.

Master Chin was the last lineage holder of this style, and it would likely have vanished from the world entirely had McNeil not preserved it. The system comprises three forms plus supplemental exercises. Though the forms appear short, when performed with full lunging power they become an intense endurance workout. Sifu James Doty, one of McNeil's senior students, had the rare honor of learning the three Tzu Men forms directly from Master Chin himself when traveling with McNeil to Taiwan in 1988.

> ***"There are literally hundreds of External styles but only four true Internal styles. Together they represent a complete path from physical fighting skill to spiritual transformation."***

CHAPTER 4

Core Techniques & Training Methods

Traditional internal kung-fu is not merely a collection of forms. It is a complete system of physical cultivation — demanding, progressive, and deeply practical. The methods described in this chapter have been refined over centuries, and every detail matters. McNeil's teachers were uncompromising about quality: 'It is not quantity but quality that counts.'

Advanced Iron Hand Training

Iron Hand is a conditioning method designed to transform the human hand into an instrument of tremendous power without calluses, deformity, or injury. The term refers not to a fist alone but to all striking surfaces of the hand — the palm, fingers, back of hand, and wrist. Taoist masters summarized its paradox: 'Beware of a man with soft hands.'

The training sequence is progressive. The practitioner begins by striking into a bag filled with soybeans, then advances to sand, to iron pellets, and eventually to specialized mediums. The critical distinction from all imitative or fraudulent practices is the mandatory use of *dit da jow* — Iron Hand liniment prepared by soaking Chinese herbs in alcohol or vinegar for a year or more. This medicine prevents blood stagnation from the repeated impacts and is the reason a genuine Iron Hand practitioner's hands remain soft and free of callus throughout a lifetime of training. Neglecting the liniment risks internal hemorrhaging and permanent deformity.

Breathing and chi-kung exercises are practiced simultaneously with the physical conditioning, directing chi into the hands and strengthening them from the inside. Advanced levels include learning to penetrate the skin — a training method reserved only for practitioners of superior moral character. A genuine Iron Hand master, McNeil emphasizes, does not need tricks or staged demonstrations: 'His skill should speak for itself.'

What to Look For in an Authentic Iron Hand Practitioner:

- Never use spacers between bricks or tiles in demonstrations — spacers make breaking dramatically easier.
- Larger slabs are easier to break than smaller, denser ones.
- Hands must remain soft and smooth — calluses indicate incorrect training or missing liniment.
- Patience is a prerequisite: the hands cannot be conditioned overnight.
- Meditation and chi-kung are essential companions to physical Iron Hand conditioning.

McNeil trained Iron Hand five days per week for over ten years without missing a day, and continues the practice to this day. After more than forty years, he states: 'I do not feel I have mastered it — that is why I still practice.'

Shih Shui Kung — Bone Marrow Washing

Shih Shui Kung (pronounced 'she-sway') is the most distinctive and powerful component of the Little Nine Heaven system. Translated as 'bone marrow washing,' it is an ancient set of exercises designed to strengthen the internal organs, fill the bones with chi, increase vitality, slow the aging process, and dramatically enhance the immune system. Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung is the exclusive source of this practice in the modern world — all authentic Shih Shui lineages trace back to him, his book, or his students.

The system exists in two forms: a Men's practice and a Women's practice, each harnessing the body's sexual essence and converting it to chi energy that suffuses the body down into the bone marrow. This Internal alchemy, practiced over time, progressively transforms the physical body's energy and strengthens it against disease and age from the inside out. Practitioners describe measurable health benefits including increased bone density, improved hormonal health, enhanced sexual function, sharper physical sensitivity, and a subjective experience of growing vitality as the years progress.

McNeil was uniquely qualified by Grandmaster Chiao to teach both the men's and women's forms — an honor Chiao stated he had never extended to anyone else. Standard training is approximately ten days, four hours per day, typically in private or small-group settings. After more than four decades of practice, acupuncturists in Korea who tested McNeil's internal organ health using diagnostic equipment reported that his internal body registered as that of a young man.

The 18 Ground Maneuvers

Among the most demanding technical elements of the L9H system are the Eighteen Ground Maneuvers — a set of grappling and floor-fighting techniques unique to Little Nine Heaven. Grandmaster Chiao taught these to McNeil in Taiwan during one of his annual training visits, with the training taking place on Chiao's polished marble floor over a period of two intense weeks.

The core principle is simultaneous defensive and offensive action: from a standing position, the practitioner blocks an incoming punch while dropping to the ground behind the opponent in a single flowing movement — no break-fall, no preparation, striking the opponent's legs as the body falls. After approximately one hundred repetitions on marble in the first session alone, McNeil's wife left the room unable to watch. Grandmaster Chiao's assessment when she returned: 'There are not many people today who could have done that. He is a remarkable man who will let nothing defeat him. I know now that I chose wisely.'

Chi Kung and Taoist Meditation

No technical skill in the internal arts can be fully realized without the parallel development of the mind through Chi Kung (breath and energy work) and Taoist meditation. Chi Kung practice directs the breath to the Tan Tien, builds the body's energy reservoir, and keeps the meridians open and flowing. Meditation develops the mental qualities — stillness, concentration, and emotional regulation — without which chi cannot be consciously directed.

The Five Stages of Taoist Cultivation:

1. **Centering** — Developing continuous self-observation: thoughts, feelings, body, and surroundings. Opening and strengthening tendons, sinews, and bones through internal kung-fu forms.
2. **Inner Journey** — Clearing negative conditioning, resolving internal conflict, and stabilizing the mind. Learning to separate desires from needs.
3. **Chi Cultivation** — Using standing, moving, and sitting methods to activate, harmonize, and develop the chi field for health.
4. **Recovery of True Mind** — Cultivating and unifying the Three Treasures: Ching (essence), Chi (energy), and Shen (spirit). Marrow washing of the spinal cord and brain.
5. **Dissolution** — The advanced stage of complete absorption into the Tao — described by those who have reached it as a conscious death experience while still alive. Very few arrive here.

The Eight Section Brocade (Ba Duan Jin) is taught as a foundational warm-up exercise, improving circulation, increasing energy, and sharpening the senses before deeper practice. The 'Three Ones' meditation — a specific L9H practice — unifies attention on three internal focal points simultaneously, developing the concentration needed for advanced chi direction.

The Eight Fundamentals of Hsing-I

The Eight Fundamentals are the structural alignment principles that govern every movement in Hsing-I — and by extension, underpin all internal kung-fu practice. They are most clearly observed in the San Ti (Three Powers) standing posture, the foundational training position of the style.

- **The Three Press-Ups** — Head (lifted to allow chi to travel up the spine), Tongue (pressed to palate to connect the Du and Ren meridians and complete the small circulation), and Palm (pressed outward to extend chi to the extremities).
- **The Three Suppresses** — Shoulders (sunk inward and down, emptying the chest and directing strength to the elbows), Hands (suppressed with the upper arms, poised to grab), and Teeth (suppressing downward to strengthen the jaw and bones).
- **The Three Rounds** — Back (slightly rounded, 'Bears Shoulders,' for powerful waist transmission), Chest (concave and empty for full strength and smooth breathing), and Hands (rounded in the Tiger's Mouth for chi flow and grasping power).
- **The Three Sensitives** — Eyes (alert and fierce, passing information to the mind), Hands (sensitive to 'feel' and 'listen,' eventually becoming like eyes), and Heart (alert and quick — the TCM emotional mind balanced with the wisdom mind of the brain).
- **The Three Holdings** — Tan Tien (filled with chi as the reservoir of life), Breath (directed to control the mind and optimize the chi), and Arms (positioned for protection and chi flow to the extremities).
- **The Three Sinkings** — Chi (sunk to the Tan Tien for centering and power), Shoulders (sinking down to allow chi to flow freely to the hands), and Elbows (sinking to protect the ribs and direct chi to the palms).
- **The Three Curves** — Elbows (curved like a drawn bow, storing energy), Wrists (curved to allow natural chi flow and increase wrist and finger strength), and Knees (curved as the suspension system of the body for stable, level movement).
- **The Three Straightenings** — Neck (upright with relaxed suppleness for chi to reach the crown), Spine (straight so the lower back cannot collapse and rob power), and Knees (aligned straight along the foot line, though slightly bent when viewed from the side).

These eight groups govern not just external alignment but the Internal body as well — when correctly embodied, they allow chi and blood to flow through meridians, vessels, bones, and organs in their correct position. 'Only when these points are totally embedded in each movement can a practitioner expect to benefit from them in terms of both health and martial abilities.'

CHAPTER 5

Philosophy, Lineage & Legacy

Why the Old Ways Matter

Throughout the newsletters that form the basis of this guide, one theme recurs with unmistakable urgency: the old styles of kung-fu are in danger of disappearing. The rise of Wu-Shu — the acrobatic, performance-oriented modern Chinese martial arts — and the dominance of MMA competition culture have pushed genuine traditional systems to the margins. Forms practice is dismissed as irrelevant by fighters who have never understood what forms actually contain.

McNeil is unambiguous on this point. The forms of the Internal arts are not routines — they are medicine, encoded movement libraries, and chi-cultivation tools simultaneously. They were designed and refined by geniuses over centuries. Altering them is not improvement; it is loss. 'I want my master's systems to carry on for many years to come without change.'

On Titles and Authenticity

One of the most consistent concerns in the newsletters is the proliferation of false masters. McNeil is forthright about the tests he used when searching for teachers early in his training: he would enter schools pretending to know nothing, in order to observe the teacher's true quality. He encountered instructors who claimed everything and knew nothing; who had power without skill; who had grace without application. The problem has only grown worse.

'Too many people are worried about quickly achieving such titles as Master or Grand Master. It is not the title that will make you good, but the right teacher, dedication, and the many hours and years that you really train. And I stress: really train. You must always be honest — not only with your teachers, but with all people, and, above all, with yourself. Only then will you gain genuine respect.'

The Global Spread of Little Nine Heaven

Without marketing budgets or institutional backing, working entirely through personal relationships and word of mouth, Sifu McNeil has taught the L9H curriculum in 27 countries across six continents. Students and lineage holders are active in England, Scotland, Germany, Denmark, Norway, Sweden, Spain, Russia, Ukraine, France, Poland, Japan, Taiwan, China, Thailand, Vietnam, the Philippines, South Africa, Kenya, Ecuador, Canada, and throughout the United States.

On April 8, 2016, the Chinese government formally welcomed the Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao system back to its homeland at Yi Wu-Lu Mountain — acknowledging what had once been considered lost. Plans are underway to build a new Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao temple honoring Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung and the lineage holders. The house where Chiao grew up is being preserved as a museum.

Little Nine Heaven Incorporated

To ensure the survival of these systems beyond any single teacher's lifetime, Little Nine Heaven Incorporated was established as a non-profit organization. The organization accepts tax-deductible donations and works to preserve, document, and transmit the complete L9H curriculum. The goal, in McNeil's words, is simple: 'When I am gone, this beautiful, powerful, and magnificent system will live on forever to help improve the health and well-being of mankind.'

More information is available at **www.littlenineheaven.org**.

> ***"The foundation was laid years ago for destiny to become reality. The tragic loss of my beloved son had to be for me to fulfill my destiny — as now I have many sons and daughters all over the world."***
>
> ***— Sifu James W. McNeil***

CHAPTER 6

Psychic Healing

Among all the arts Sifu McNeil has studied and preserved, none extends the reach of internal kung-fu further into the realm of spirit and medicine than Psychic Healing. Introduced to him by Master Hsu Ting-Ming in 1988, this practice draws on the same fundamental currency as every other discipline in the L9H system — chi — but directs it outward, through the hands and the focused intent of the mind, for the purpose of healing the bodies and spirits of others.

To be a true psychic, one must either be born with the gift or experience something so dramatic that it reshapes one's destiny entirely. To become a psychic healer, however, requires both natural capacity and dedicated study under a great teacher. Beyond technique, the healer must possess genuine human feeling: care for others, the capacity to love, the desire to help, and robust internal energy built through years of cultivation. Without these qualities, no technique can bridge the gap between practitioner and patient.

The Teacher: Master Hsu Ting-Ming

During his already rich period of martial training in 1988, McNeil was introduced to Master Hsu Ting-Ming and began studying what the master called 'a different style of kung-fu' — Psychic Healing. Their first formal lesson ran from October 17th through the 21st. On the final day, Master Hsu presented McNeil with a signed and dated copy of his book — a rare mark of recognition from teacher to new student.

Master Hsu's assessment of McNeil was direct and prophetic: 'I can see you have a special power within you for healing and helping people. Not many people are like you. Stay and learn and one day you will see I am right.' McNeil trained with him for the next two years, practicing Psychic Healing alongside his internal kung-fu systems and meditation. The changes were palpable — not a muscular or martial strength, but a different quality of inner power altogether: a growing capacity to sense, direct, and transmit chi for the benefit of others.

What Psychic Healing Is

Psychic Healing rests on a principle both simple and ancient: the human body possesses an inborn capacity to accumulate subtle bio-electric energy — chi — and a trained practitioner can transmit that energy through the hands into another person's body, activating the patient's own natural capacity for healing.

No instruments, drugs, or external tools are required. The only tools are love, compassion, the willingness of the mind to heal, and chi directed into the fingers and palms. The psychic healer applies mind and hands together with focused intent, seeking total relief of suffering and the remission of illness. Complete confidence in the healer on the patient's part is essential — doubt creates an internal resistance that weakens the transmission.

Patients experience healing energy differently. Some feel a tingling sensation; others a transmitting warmth. Some describe intense heat — like a branding iron burning away the illness — while others experience it as a soft and soothing breeze. In all cases this invisible energy provides healing not only at the physical level but at the mental and emotional level as well.

Some psychic healers enter a trance state to deepen the work, calling upon the universal force to amplify the energy flowing through them. In the L9H system the practitioner works in silence throughout — unlike many other healing traditions, no talking takes place during the session. The goal is to become a clear channel rather than the source: McNeil has always refused payment for his healing work, explaining, 'The healing of your body was not me, but an outside force much stronger than me.'

The Three Uses of Psychic Healing

The L9H system recognises three distinct ways in which Psychic Healing can be applied:

- **Healing Oneself** — The first and most foundational application. Even a healthy person benefits, because the body and spirit change with every moment of life. Self-healing maintains internal balance, strengthens the chi reservoir, and is the essential ground upon which all outward healing work rests.
- **Teaching Others to Heal Themselves** — A less energetically demanding form of practice that yields the greatest long-term benefit for students. Because the psychic healer perceives subtleties others cannot, sharing those observations guides the student toward self-correction and serves as powerful preventive medicine.
- **Healing Others Directly** — The most powerful and most demanding application. Transmitting healing chi directly into another person's body is deeply exhausting for the practitioner but highly effective for the patient, and requires the greatest internal development.

The Three Methods

Alongside the three uses, the L9H system distinguishes three methods of how healing can be physically performed:

- **With Touch** — Direct physical contact between the healer's hands and the patient's body. This is the most immediate and intense transmission of healing chi.
- **Without Touch** — Healing transmitted across a space without physical contact, using focused intent and projection of chi.
- **A Combination of Touch and No-Touch** — A fluid integration of both approaches, moving between contact and distance as the healing requires. No talking takes place at any point.

The Three Levels of Training

Psychic Healing is transmitted in three progressive levels. Each must be mastered before the next can be approached.

1. Level One — Building Energy and Confidence

The student works entirely on their own body and mind: building internal energy and health through chi-kung and meditation, strengthening the chi reservoir, and developing the self-confidence and inner stillness that all healing requires. No outward healing work is attempted until this foundation is solid.

2. Level Two — Mudras, Sending and Receiving

At the second level the student learns the power of mudras — sacred hand positions that direct chi in specific patterns — and develops the ability to consciously send energy outward and receive it inward. This bidirectional sensitivity is essential for reading the energetic state of a patient and for adjusting the healing response accordingly.

3. Level Three — Transmitting Healing Power

The final level completes the circuit: the practitioner learns to transmit healing chi to another person with precision and sustained intent. At this level the hands of the psychic healer resonate with what the tradition calls divine energy. A touch from such hands is immediately felt by the recipient; whoever is held or touched will become animated and will always remember the encounter — this is the beautiful power of feeling.

Healing in Practice — A Firsthand Account

A few years after beginning his study with Master Hsu Ting-Ming, McNeil was asked to help a Chinese friend of his wife's who suffered severe pain beneath her shoulder blade from an accident. She had already sought help from chi-kung masters, doctors, acupuncturists, and herbalists in China and Taiwan, and an

American physician had finally recommended surgery. With nothing to lose, she came to McNeil.

He worked on her for about an hour. Sweat poured from his body. His hands burned at the site of the injury and she cried out at the intensity of the heat. A voice arose from somewhere deep inside McNeil — not his own, he would later say — that simply said 'shut up.' A few minutes later he said quietly: 'Your pain is gone.' She stood up and it was. She offered money; he refused, saying that what had healed her was not him but 'an outside force much stronger than me.' To this day she visits his family and brings fruit.

'I have healed a few other men and women,' McNeil wrote, 'and have always been successful.'

The Universal Nature of the Healing Touch

Every human being already possesses some degree of healing touch. A warm embrace soothes a crying child; a handshake lifts the spirits of a frightened friend; a mother's palm on her baby's back brings sleep. These are not metaphors — they are expressions of the same chi that, when deliberately cultivated and directed, becomes the concentrated force of the psychic healer.

What distinguishes the trained practitioner is the degree to which that natural capacity has been developed and made available at will. By simple intent and movement of the hands, the proficient practitioner can channel healing energy for others without elaborate preparation. Psychic Healing is ultimately a self-growth tool as much as a medical practice — it expands awareness of oneself as a spiritual being, and helps one live from a stronger, more empowered level of consciousness. It is available to anyone, regardless of religion, creed, or prior spiritual experience, who is willing to do the internal work required to develop it.

> ***"The only tool required is love, compassion, and willingness of the mind to heal while putting chi into the fingers and palms. No medicines are required — only the medicine that lives within us all."***
>
> ***— Sifu James W. McNeil***

A Closing Word from Sifu McNeil

I am a simple man and I live by the truth. I have been teaching the same way that my teachers taught me, because it is important to keep their systems pure. Throughout my life as a kung-fu teacher, I have taught everyone with respect — and I will always live by the truth.

There is nothing easy about this path. The road is long, the training is hard, and real knowledge requires real sacrifice. I sold my guns to buy a plane ticket to Taiwan. I waited three hours on a master's porch three times without complaint. I dropped to a marble floor one hundred times in a single afternoon. Every step was worth it.

To those of you who are interested in learning: the first step is the most important one. Walk through the door. Find the right teacher. Practice with honesty and humility. Do not chase titles. Do not rush. The art will reveal itself to you in proportion to what you give it.

To my students, grand-students, and great grand-students around the world: keep the systems pure. Train every day. Respect your teachers and each other. And when you are done training for the day, turn to the person you love, hold them, and say: 'I love you and thank you.' That is also part of the art.

Sincerely,

Sifu James W. McNeil
Gate Keeper, Little Nine Heaven Wu Tao System
www.littlenineheaven.com | siful9h@gmail.com

Publications & Accomplishments

Over a career spanning more than five decades, Sifu James W. McNeil has produced a body of written and recorded work that stands alone in the world of traditional Chinese martial arts. From landmark magazine covers to internationally distributed instructional DVDs, from newspaper front pages in Poland to books on Taoist internal cultivation, his output represents an unmatched effort to document, share, and preserve these ancient arts for future generations.

Books

Sifu McNeil has authored fourteen books covering every major area of the L9H curriculum — from combat-focused studies of Hsing-I and Splashing Hands to deeply personal accounts of his training with Grandmaster Chiao, and from Taoist health and longevity practices to the lost wisdom traditions of internal cultivation.

1.	*Hsing-I Kung Fu*	June 1996
2.	*Ancient Lovemaking Secrets (1st edition)*	September 1998
3.	*Medicine Within Our Bodies*	October 2007
4.	*Unity Between Tai Chi and the Tao Te Ching*	October 2007
5.	*Ancient Lovemaking Secrets (2nd edition)*	October 2007
6.	*Splashing Hand Kung Fu*	July 2017
7.	*Hsing-I Kung Fu (revised)*	September 2018
8.	*Last of the Living Legends*	September 2019
9.	*Training with the Legendary Grandmaster Chiao Chang-Hung*	February 2020

10.	*Chinese Psychic Healing*	June 2021
11.	*Iron Hand Training*	June 2021
12.	*Lost Taoist Wisdom*	May 2022
13.	*Lost Taoist Wisdom of L9H: Techniques for Internal Cultivation*	April 2023
14.	*Ancient Lovemaking Secrets (3rd edition)*	March 2025

Instructional DVDs

In addition to his books, Sifu McNeil produced an extensive library of instructional DVDs that have reached students in dozens of countries — making high-quality instruction in rare arts accessible to practitioners who cannot study in person.

1. *Chinese Lovemaking Secrets* — Parts 1 & 2
2. *Taoist Lovemaking Secrets* — Parts 1 & 2
3. *Ancient Chinese Art of Tui-Na*
4. *Chen Style Tai-Chi* — Parts 1 & 2
5. *Chinese Acupressure Massage for Health*
6. *Mastering Hsing-I* — 1 through 10
7. *Shaolin Staff Form*
8. *Advanced Iron Hand*
9. *Tien Gunn* — Parts 1 & 2
10. *Splashing Hands* — 1 through 10
11. *Butterfly Knives*
12. *Eight Section Brocade*

Inside Kung Fu Magazine Articles

Sifu McNeil was one of the most prolific contributors to *Inside Kung Fu* — appearing in its pages more than 38 times over three decades.

1.	*Original Chen Style – A Generation from Extinction?*	April 1987
2.	*The Devastating Fighting Power of Hsing-I*	September 1987
3.	*Techniques for Developing Iron Hand*	October 1987

4.	*Nine Little Heaven Kung Fu: A Star is Born*	March 1988
5.	*The Character Behind Tzu Men Chuan*	May 1989
6.	*The Devastating Strikes of Hsing-I*	June 1989
7.	*Chen Family Tai Chi – Where It All Began*	
8.	*Hsing-I*	August 1989
9.	*Stances*	February 1990
10.	*Strength Inside and Out*	June 1990
11.	*He's Strong Both Inside and Out*	Feb 1991 / Feb 1992
12.	*Little Nine Heaven – The Forgotten Martial Arts*	July 1992
13.	*The Magic of Internal Martial Arts*	October 1992
14.	*The Changing Styles of Hsing-I*	September 1993
15.	*Finding the Balance*	September 1993
16.	*The Dying Art of Chinese Streetfighting – Splashing Hands*	August 1994
17.	*Little Nine Heaven Kung Fu*	March 1995
18.	*The Little Nine Heaven Retreat*	August 1996
19.	*Internal 2 Man Fighting Forms*	October 1997
20.	*Hands Like Stone in 100 Days*	July 1998
21.	*Internal Arts*	May 2001
22.	*5 Secrets to Hsing-I Power*	May 2002
23.	*Pa Kua*	March 2003
24.	*The Revival of Splashing Hands*	April 2003
25.	*The Complete Iron Hand Training Method*	April 2004
26.	*Hsing-I – A Boxer's Secret Weapon*	March 2005
27.	*Martial Arts Magic Elixir*	January 2006
28.	*A Splash of Kung Fu*	May 2006
29.	*Tzu Men Chuan's 18 Characters*	June 2006
30.	*Your Cup Runneth Over*	November 2006
31.	*Honor Thy Master (Ba-Kua)*	September 2008
32.	*Splashing Hands*	April 2009

33.	*MMA's Secret Weapon*	June 2009
34.	*Build Rock Hard Forearms*	August 2009
35.	*A Splash of Kung Fu*	August 2010
36.	*Hsing-I*	January 2010
37.	*What is Hsing-I?*	June 2011

Magazine Covers

Sifu McNeil has graced the cover of six major martial arts publications — a distinction reserved for the most respected practitioners in the field.

1.	*Inside Kung Fu*	August 1989
2.	*Martial Arts Magazine (Masters Series)*	July 1991
3.	*Martial Arts Masters*	March 1995
4.	*Inside Kung Fu*	July 1998
5.	*Secrets of Internal Kung Fu*	May 2001
6.	*Inside Kung Fu (Center Page)*	March 2003

Other Magazine Features

1.	*Internal Arts Magazine – XingYiQuan, Taoist Boxing Art*	September 1989
2.	*Martial Arts Magazine*	July 1991
3.	*Advanced Self-Defense – Stances*	July 1991
4.	*Masters & Styles – Hsing-I*	1992
5.	*Masters & Styles – Fighting*	May 1993
6.	*Orange Coast Magazine*	July 1993
7.	*Martial Arts Masters – Hsing-I Kung-Fu*	March 1995
8.	*Fighters (Sweden) – Hsing-I*	1997
9.	*Dynamic Exercises – Iron Hand*	October 1997
10.	*Samurai – Different Styles*	February 1999
11.	*Bell Magazine – Ancient Lovemaking Secrets*	June 1999

12.	*Secrets of Internal Kung Fu Magazine*	May 2001

International Magazine Features

1.	*Martial Arts Illustrated (England)*	January 1996
2.	*Martial Arts Illustrated (England) – Splashing Hands*	November 1997
3.	*Combat Magazine (England) – Sifu McNeil Visits England Again*	1998
4.	*Kung Fu Magazine (Italy) – Hsing-I & Chen Tai Chi*	1999
5.	*Combat Magazine (England) – Secret Powers of Hsing-I*	2000
6.	*Saudi Arabia – Wudang Gong Fu & Hsing-I*	2001

Newspaper Articles

1.	*The Register (Orange County) – Kung Fu Master Uses Healing Technique*	August 4, 1980
2.	*The Orange County Register*	October 1985
3.	*World News (Chinese)*	December 1991
4.	*Poland News (Glos Slup) – Front Page*	1997
5.	*Taiwan News*	1999
6.	*World News (Chinese)*	October 2008

Countries Sifu McNeil Has Taught In

Twenty-eight countries on six continents have welcomed Sifu McNeil as a teacher. The list below reflects the depth of this global reach — many of these countries have been visited not once, but many times over the course of his career.

- **United States** Many times
- **Russia** Many times
- **Ukraine** Many times
- **England** Many times
- **Taiwan** Many times
- **Ecuador** 3 times
- **Portugal** 2 times
- **Poland** 2 times
- **Germany** 2 times
- **Japan** 2 times

- **Canada** Many times
- **Thailand** 8 times
- **South Africa** 5 times
- **China** 5 times
- **Hong Kong** 4 times
- **Sweden** 4 times
- **Ireland** 3 times
- **Vietnam** 3 times
- **Spain** 3 times
- **France** 2 times
- **South Korea** 2 times
- **Turkey** 2 times
- **Denmark** 2 times
- **Mexico** 1 time
- **Switzerland** 1 time
- **Philippines** 1 time
- **Colombia** 1 time
- **Scotland** 1 time

"It is my sincerest hope that these arts will continue to grow and flourish in every corner of the world — bringing health, wisdom, and the spirit of the ancient Taoist masters to all who seek them."

— Sifu James W. McNeil